

C19 B EDUCATION AND SUPPORT | O (MAX : 2 PT)

Intent : Support career growth by reducing educational and professional advancement barriers.

Summary : This WELL feature requires financial support for education and/or mentoring opportunities to support career advancement and financial stability.

Issue : Creating supportive programs for education, mentorship and sponsorship can positively impact employee financial health and opportunities.¹ Such support can have short and long-term effects on many dimensions of an employee's life and can benefit other members of their immediate family including spouses, children and parents.² Systemic discrimination and the resulting disparities in access to economic, social and educational support have historically kept marginalized populations from achieving gainful employment.^{3,4} Financial wellness also impacts mental health, housing stability and food security.⁵

Solutions : Studies have shown that minorities and women significantly benefit from peer-to-peer mentors and sponsors who champion them.^{4,6,7} Sponsors provide a deeper level of mentorship to their proteges.⁸ Through exposure and relationships, they provide career advancement opportunities for the protegee when they are "in and out of the room".⁸ Mentorship develops trust between the two parties, creating a foundation for a successful relationship between mentor and mentee.⁴ Mentorship surveys also reveal satisfaction amongst employees within such programs – in the United States, 71% of employees with a mentor say their company provides them with excellent or good opportunities to advance their careers.⁷ Employees may also benefit from other support options such as speaker sessions, workshops and seminars.⁹ Guest speakers can help advance professional development, spark new ideas and offer follow-up training opportunities.¹⁰ Providing subsidized financial assistance to promote education for marginalized populations may create more opportunities for career advancement and, therefore, bring greater financial stability for individuals and their families.¹¹⁻¹³ Research from the United States found that 80% of employees agreed that their employer's tuition assistance program makes them more likely to stay with the organization, and 71% of respondents rated tuition assistance as the best or among the best benefits offered by their employer (excluding health care benefits).^{1,14} Financial assistance for education and peer-to-peer mentorship positively impacts all employees, and in particular, marginalized populations.^{7,13}

PART 1 ESTABLISH EDUCATION AND SUPPORT (MAX : 2 PT)

For All Spaces:

Option 1: Tuition assistance

The project or organization provides a Tuition Assistance Program (TAP), which may be limited to select institutions, to all eligible employees that meets the following requirement:

- a. Pays for a minimum of 75% of educational expenses for all enrolled courses each term/year (including tuition, program fees and books/materials) for vocational training, undergraduate, graduate, certificate courses and similar educational goals. Assistance is structured per the table below:

Tier	Tuition Assistance Structure	Point Value
1	Reimbursements for educational expenses	1 point
2	Direct payments for educational expenses	2 point

OR

Option 2: Mentorship program

The project or organization provides a mentorship or sponsorship program that meets the following requirements:

- a. A process for matching mentor to mentee and/or sponsor to protégé (e.g., interest form).
- b. A plan development process co-created between mentor and mentee or sponsor and protégé to identify the needs, goals and objectives. The plan should be customized and focus on individual strengths, personality, skills and workstyles.
- c. A process by which mentees and protégés report on meetings between the mentor/mentee or sponsor/protégé and participation in activities recommended by the mentor or sponsor.
- d. An allocated budget for specialized resources or training related to professional development (e.g., conferences, courses, assessments, workshops, group sessions) for all participating mentees and/or protégés.^{15,16}
- e. Mandatory training about explicit and implicit bias (in the form of educational seminars, workshops, classes or on-demand modules) for all participating employees before engagement in the program.

Note : This Option is worth 1 point

Note :

This feature is a beta strategy and has an additional documentation requirement (beta feature feedback form). The feedback form supports IWBI in developing new features that are effective and applicable to projects around the world.

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